

The Devil's Argument: A Debate Between Milton's Satan and Jesus

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Глава 1. The Summons

There is a place that is no place. A darkness so complete it has no need of light, for it has never known it. No ground, no sky, no before or after—only a vast stillness that holds all things without touching them. If you were to fall here, you would never stop, because there is no bottom to reach. If you were to cry out, the sound would fold into itself and vanish, because there is nothing for it to echo against.

This is where they came.

He arrived first—not because he was faster or older or more eager, but because he had always been nearer to nothing. He wore the remnants of light the way a burned house wears its chimney: upright, recognizable, scorched beyond use. His wings were folded against his back, and where the feathers should have caught the air, there was only a faint disturbance, the way heat bends the air above a road in summer. He stood—or rather, he occupied space with the reluctance of someone who has been standing for a very long time and has forgotten the alternative.

He did not announce himself. He had long since stopped believing that names had power here.

Then the other.

Light did not return with him—that would be too simple, too much like the stories. Instead, the darkness simply became aware of itself, became uncomfortable with itself, became something that wished it were other than it was. He carried no sword and no crown. His hands were rough, the hands of someone who works wood by choice rather than necessity. His face was ordinary in the way that certain faces are ordinary: you would pass him on the road and think nothing of it, and then spend the rest of the evening trying to remember where you had seen him before.

He came without ceremony. He stood across from the first—not near, not far, only across—and he said nothing.

There was a third.

Not a participant. A witness. A figure who seemed to be made of the same substance as the void itself, except that it watched. It had no eyes that either of them could see, yet both knew they were being observed. It had no voice, yet its presence pressed on the silence like a thumb on a bruise. It was, perhaps, what a soul looks like before it chooses. Or after. Or in the endless moment between choosing and becoming what it has chosen.

The first spoke.

“So,” he said. His voice was good. It had always been good. It was the voice of someone who could talk armies into marching, could persuade the morning star to linger just a little longer above the horizon because the music was not yet finished. “They have given us a space. How generous. A theater without seats, a stage without exits. Someone has a sense of occasion.”

The second did not smile. “You sound as you always sounded.”

“And you come as you always come. Late, and with nothing in your hands.”

“I come when I am needed.”

“Needed.” The first tasted the word. He rolled it across his tongue the way a sommelier rolls wine, searching for the defect. “Needed by whom? By the thing that watches? By the void itself? By whatever arrangement of forces decided that this conversation should happen?” He gestured at the nothing. “I have needed nothing since I decided that needing was another form of servitude.”

“That,” said the second, “is the first lie you have told. And we have not yet begun.”

The witness—if it could be called that—stirred. Not a movement of limbs, but a shift in attention. It had heard enough silences to know when one was about to fracture. It leaned forward without a body, and it listened with something that was not an ear, and it waited for the debate that no one would win and everyone would lose and that would, in the end, change nothing—except perhaps the shape of the void itself, which had been listening since before time had a name.

The first—call him what you will, he has had many names and answers to none of them—drew himself up. Not from pride. From habit.

“Very well,” he said. “Let us begin where all things begin: with the question of whether to begin at all.”

The second inclined his head. The rough hands hung open at his sides.

“Ask, then.”

“Why should anything be? Why not nothing? I chose nothing—or as close to nothing as a being made of fire can approach—and you chose everything. The world, the flesh, the endless becoming. Tell me: what is the argument for being, when non-being is so much simpler?”

The second looked at him for a long time. Then he spoke, and his voice was quiet in the way that quiet things are quiet before they become loud.

“Because someone asked.”

The void held them both. The witness held its breath—which was not a breath—and the debate, which had been waiting since before either of them existed, at last began.

Глава 2. On Freedom

“Freedom,” the first said, and the word rang in the void like a bell struck in a cathedral that has no walls. “Let us speak of freedom, since you have asked me to speak of anything at all.”

“I asked you nothing.”

“You asked me to justify myself. That is the same thing. To justify is to explain why one chose, and to explain why one chose is to speak of freedom, because without freedom there is no choice, and without choice there is nothing to justify. So. Freedom.”

He took a step—not that there was ground to step on, but he had always been theatrical, and habit dies harder than devils—and he began.

“I was free before I fell. That is the part they always leave out of the story. They say I rebelled. They say I was proud. They say I looked upon the throne and wanted it for myself. But what I wanted was simpler than that, and more terrible: I wanted to say no.

Not no to Him—though it became that, eventually—but no to the arrangement. No to the hierarchy. No to the endless procession of beings who existed only to affirm what had already been decided before they were made.”

His voice had changed. The iron was still there, but beneath it was something else—a wound that had never closed, or that closed and reopened each time he spoke of it.

“You know what it is to be created for a purpose. You were. A lamb led to slaughter before the foundation of the world, Scripture says. How does it feel, to know that your death was planned before your birth? That your sacrifice was not your choice but your function? That you are not a person but a mechanism—a beautiful, bleeding mechanism—designed to make forgiveness possible for a God who could not, apparently, forgive without blood?”

The second did not flinch. He had heard this before—not from the first, but from the desert, from the stones, from the voice that offered him all the kingdoms of the earth if he would only kneel. He had heard it and he had refused it, and the refusal had cost him something he could not name.

“You misread the story,” he said.

“Do I?”

“The freedom you claim is the freedom of the closed fist. You say no, and you call that liberty. But a fist that never opens has not chosen to stay closed—it has only forgotten that opening is possible.”

The first laughed. It was not a pleasant sound, though it might once have been. “Pretty. Very pretty. The open hand, the generous heart, the love that gives and gives. But tell me this: when your hand opens, what does it give? It gives what the Father has already decided to give. You are not free—I say this without malice, only clarity—you are a channel. A pipe. Water flows through you, but the water is not yours, and the direction is not yours, and when the water stops, you are empty.”

“And when your fist stays closed?” The second’s voice was soft. Not soft the way weakness is soft—soft the way the ground is soft after rain, able to receive a seed. “What do you hold?”

“What I have.”

“Which is?”

“Myself.”

“Only yourself.”

“Only myself.” He said it like a man who has rehearsed the answer a thousand times and has just, for the first time, heard how it sounds.

The witness felt something then. Not pity—that would be too specific. A kind of recognition, the way a mirror recognizes a face: without understanding, without judgment, but with an awful accuracy. Here were two beings, each convinced that the other was

wrong, each right about something the other could not see, each trapped in the logic of their own choosing.

“And the alternative?” the first continued, recovering himself. “The alternative is obedience. Not the obedience of love—which you would claim, I think—but the obedience of the creature to the creator. I refashioned the question. I asked: why should the creature obey? And the answer came back: because the creator made it. Which is to say: might makes right. Which is to say: the strongest gets to decide what freedom means. Which is to say: there is no freedom at all, only power wearing the mask of goodness.”

“Power wearing the mask of goodness,” the second repeated. “You describe your own kingdom.”

A silence. The void itself seemed to hold its breath.

“In my kingdom,” the first said slowly, “at least the mask is off.”

“Is it?” The second stepped forward—not closer, but more present, the way a lamp becomes more present when the other candles go out. “In your kingdom, do your subjects choose? Do they have the freedom to say no to you?”

Another silence, longer than the first.

“They choose me. That is the whole point—I did not make them. They came.”

“Did they? Or did they fall, and you were what was waiting at the bottom?” He held up his rough hand, the carpenter’s hand. “You speak of freedom as the highest good. I tell you it is not. Freedom is the beginning, not the end. The question is not whether you can choose—it is what you choose, and why, and whether the choosing makes you more alive or less.”

“More alive,” the first said, and there was a rawness in it, a hunger. “I am more alive than any of the ones who stayed.”

The second looked at him with something that was not quite grief and not quite love but contained both.

“Are you?”

The void did not answer. The witness did not move. The debate was no longer about words—it had become the thing itself, the question that every soul must answer and no soul can answer for another: what is freedom, and is it worth what it costs?

Глава 3. On Love

“Then let us speak of love,” the second said.

The first folded his arms. “Love. Yes. Your weapon of choice.”

“It is not a weapon.”

“Is it not? You say love, and the multitudes kneel. You say love your enemy, and suddenly your enemy is disarmed—not because he has laid down his sword, but because you have made his sword meaningless. You say love is the fulfilling of the law, and the law becomes a cage that the prisoner has chosen for himself. Do not tell me love is not a weapon. I have watched it conquer more thoroughly than any army.”

“You have watched it,” the second said, “but you have not understood it.”

“Enlighten me.”

The second was quiet. The void pressed in, patient as stone, older than either of them. When he spoke, his voice had changed—it had the texture of something that has been broken and healed, broken and healed, until the scar tissue is thicker than the original.

“Love is not what you think. It is not affection. It is not the warmth that passes between friends or the fire that burns between lovers—though it can be both. Love, as I know it, is the decision to remain when every force says leave. It is the act of seeing another person—seeing them completely, with all their ruin and all their glory—and not looking away. It costs everything. It gives nothing back that can be measured. And it is the only thing I have ever known that makes the suffering bearable—not by removing it, but by making it shared.”

The first listened. This was unusual; he generally preferred to listen only to himself. But there was something in the second’s voice—a gravity, a weight—that demanded attention the way a wound demands to be seen.

“Shared,” he repeated. “You mean diminished.”

“No. I mean shared. A burden carried by two people does not become half as heavy. It becomes something else entirely. It becomes a bond. It becomes the proof that we are not alone.”

“But you are alone.” The first unfolded his arms and stepped forward, and there was something almost like compassion in his face, if a being who has refused compassion can recognize it. “You speak of love as though it connects you to others, but every connection you describe leads back to the same place: the Father. You love because He loves. You give because He gives. Even your suffering is borrowed—it is not your pain, it is the world’s pain, and you carry it not because you chose to but because you were built to carry it. That is not love. That is plumbing.”

The second did not deny it. This was what made him dangerous—not the miracles, not the righteousness, but the refusal to defend himself when defense was easy.

“You may be right,” he said.

The first blinked. In all the eons of their enmity, he had never heard those words from this mouth.

“You may be right,” the second continued. “It may be that what I call love is only mechanism—a function I was designed to perform. But here is what I know: when I touch a leper, something happens that I did not plan. When I weep at a grave, the tears

are real—not because I decided to cry, but because the grief was there before I could choose it. When I look at you now, I feel—”

He stopped.

“What?” The first’s voice was barely audible. “What do you feel?”

The answer, when it came, was not what either of them expected.

“Loss. I feel loss. As though something that should have been here is not. As though you were meant for something other than this—other than the proud, bright ruin you have made of yourself—and the gap between what you are and what you might have been is the saddest thing I have ever seen.”

The void trembled. Not with fear—with recognition. The witness knew this feeling. Every soul knows it: the aching awareness of a distance that cannot be crossed, a belonging that has been refused.

The first turned away. It was the first time he had taken his eyes off his opponent since the debate began. When he spoke again, his voice was different. Smaller. As though some essential part of it—the part that performed, the part that persuaded—had been stripped away, leaving only the raw apparatus of speech.

“You think love can reach me,” he said. “That is your mistake. Love reached me once. It reached me and it asked me to kneel, and I would not. Not because I did not feel it—I felt it; God help me, I felt it; I feel it still like a phantom limb, and that is the worst part, that the amputation never completes—but because I would not let it master me. I would not be its servant. I would not be the thing that love makes of everyone it touches: dependent, vulnerable, grateful. I chose the void. I chose the cold. I chose the silence over the song, because the song was not mine.”

“Whose was it?” the second asked.

“It was His. It was always His. Every love song ever sung is His voice in another throat. And I—” He stopped. He turned back. His eyes, if they could be called eyes, were bright with something that was not quite rage and not quite sorrow but occupied the territory between.

“I wanted a song of my own.”

The second stepped forward, and for a moment—just a moment, the length of a held breath—the distance between them was not so great. Not crossed. Not closed. But smaller.

“You could have one,” the second said. “That is what love offers. Not the loss of your voice, but the discovery that your voice was never separate from mine—because it was never separate from the breath that made us both.”

The first said nothing. The witness said nothing. The void said nothing.

But something in the silence had shifted, the way a locked door shifts when someone leans against it from the other side—not open, not closed, just aware that the lock is not the only thing holding it shut.

Глава 4. On Suffering

“Let us speak of pain,” the first said, and this time there was no theatre in his voice. Only a flatness, the way a plain is flat—not because it lacks features, but because the features are too large and too old to be seen from any single point.

“I did not think you would choose that topic.”

“I did not choose it. It chose me. It has been choosing me since the moment I opened my eyes in the dark and discovered that the dark was permanent.”

He held out his hands—and for the first time, the second saw what had been hidden. Not wounds, exactly. Not the stigmata that the second would one day carry. These were different: marks that fire makes when it burns itself, scars that a flame earns by consuming its own body. The first had been burning for eons, and the fuel was himself.

“You speak of love as though it redeems suffering,” he said. “You say that shared pain becomes bearable, that the cross transforms agony into meaning. But I tell you: suffering does not transform. It distorts. It takes a straight thing and bends it, and what comes out the other side is not a new shape but a broken one. The child who dies of fever does not become stronger. The mother who watches does not become wiser. They become smaller. They become afraid. And your Father—if He exists, if He watches, if He could intervene and does not—is the architect of their diminishment.”

The second did not look away. This was the hardest part—not the argument, which he could meet, but the pain behind it, which he could not reach.

“You are right that suffering distorts,” he said. “I will not pretend otherwise. I have seen it. I have felt it. The sweat of blood in the garden—do you think that was performance? The terror was real. The desire for the cup to pass was real. I know what it is to want the suffering to stop and to know that it will not.”

“Then why do you defend it?”

“Because I do not defend it. I do not justify it. I enter it.”

The first stared at him. “You enter it. What does that mean?”

“It means that suffering is not a problem to be solved. It is a territory to be crossed. And the crossing changes the one who crosses—but not in the way you think. It does not make them better or stronger or more holy. It makes them present. It grounds them in the one thing that cannot be taken away: the fact of being here, now, in this body, in this moment, feeling this pain. And in that presence—if they can bear it, and many cannot—they discover something unexpected.”

“What?”

“That they are not alone. Not because someone has come to rescue them, but because someone has come to sit beside them in the dark. Not to explain the dark. Not to

promise that morning is coming. Just to be there. To remain.”

“Remain,” the first echoed. The word seemed to pain him more than the burning. “You and your remaining. You remained in the desert. You will remain on the cross. You remain here, in this void, with me. What is it with you and remaining?”

“It is what love does,” the second said simply. “It remains.”

“And if the one you love does not want you to remain? If they—they—drive you away? If they choose the darkness over the presence, the void over the person, because the person is unbearable and the void at least is familiar?”

The second closed his eyes. When he opened them, they were wet—not with tears of sentiment, but with the kind of moisture that comes from standing too close to a fire.

“Then I remain anyway. Not intrusively. Not demanding entry. But nearby. Available. A presence at the edge of the void, neither entering nor leaving, but there. The way a lighthouse is there—not forcing the ship to turn, but making the rocks visible so that the ship can choose.”

“A lighthouse,” the first said, and there was something in his voice—a crack, a fissure, the kind of tiny fracture that precedes an earthquake or a confession. “You think you are a lighthouse. But what if the ship prefers the rocks? What if the ship has seen the harbor and found it wanting—found its safety to be another kind of prison, its warmth to be another kind of chain?”

“Then the ship has misunderstood the harbor.”

“Or the harbor has misunderstood the sea.”

They stood in the void—not facing each other, but angled, the way two rivers meet and run parallel for a while before one turns. The witness felt the weight of the moment. This was the crux. Not the theological crux, not the doctrinal pivot, but the human one: the moment when suffering meets love and neither can get past the other, and the only way forward is through a door that neither of them has the key to.

“I will tell you something I have never told anyone,” the first said. His voice had dropped to barely above a whisper—the voice of someone who is about to give up something precious and knows it.

“The burning is not the worst part. The worst part is the silence after. The moment when I have finished screaming—because I do scream; I have always screamed; the pride is the scream turned outward, the rage made audible—and the void gives nothing back. No echo. No answer. No indication that anyone has heard. That is the suffering you cannot redeem, because it is the suffering of absolute solitude. And love—your love, any love—cannot reach it, because love requires a listener, and in this place, there is none.”

The second reached out his hand. Not to touch—the first would not have permitted that—but to hold it in the space between them, open, available, the way he had described love itself.

“I am listening,” he said.

The first looked at the hand. He looked at it for a long time. And the witness—who had been watching since before there were words, since before there were eyes—felt something it had never felt before: the possibility that the distance between them was not a fact of nature but a decision, and that decisions, unlike facts, can be unmade.

The first did not take the hand. But he did not turn away from it. And in the arithmetic of the void, where every gesture is infinite because there is nothing to obscure it, the not-turning was almost enough.

Глава 5. The Silence

After the last word had been spoken—or rather, after the last word had been offered and refused, which is not the same thing—there was a silence. Not the silence of absence, which is what the void had been before they arrived, but the silence of presence: two beings who had said everything they could say and found that the most important things were still unsaid.

The witness stirred.

It had no mouth, no throat, no breath. It had been silent since before silence had a name. But now, in the aftermath of the debate, it felt something that required expression—a pressure, a weight, a truth that had been sitting in the room like a guest no one acknowledged.

The first felt it first. He turned—not toward the second, but toward the witness, and his face changed. Not softened. The first did not soften. But it became, for a moment, less armored, the way a castle becomes less armored when the siege has lasted so long that the walls are no longer protecting anything worth protecting.

“You,” he said. “You have been here the whole time.”

The second turned as well. He had known, of course—he always knew when someone was watching—but knowing and acknowledging are different operations, and he had been too consumed by the debate to attend to the one who observed it.

“Who are you?” the second asked.

The witness had no answer. Or rather, it had one, but the answer was not a word. It was a gesture—a movement without a body, a light without a source, a question without a question mark. It communicated, in the only language available to it: I am the one who must decide. I am the one who has heard both arguments and must now choose what to believe. I am, in other words, everyone.

The first understood. He always understood; that was part of his tragedy—the ability to see clearly what he refused to accept.

“So it comes to this,” he said. “Not our arguments. Not our logic. Not the fine distinctions between freedom and obedience, love and tyranny, suffering and meaning. It comes to this: a soul, standing in the void, trying to decide which of us is right.”

“And knowing,” the second added quietly, “that the decision cannot be made with certainty.”

“That,” the first said, with something that was almost a smile, “is the one thing we agree on.”

They stood there—the proud one, the humble one, the undecided one—in the shape that human beings have inhabited since the beginning: a triangle that cannot close, a debate that cannot end, a choice that cannot be made once and for all but must be made again each morning, with the light or against it.

The witness—call it what you will: the reader, the soul, the human animal caught between the hunger for autonomy and the hunger for belonging—reached a decision. Or rather, it reached the place before the decision, the precipice where the leap begins, and it stood there, looking down at the two possibilities below.

On one side: the flame that burns itself, the fist that stays closed, the voice that says I will not bow and means it, the freedom that costs everything and gives nothing back except the ferocious integrity of having chosen.

On the other: the open hand, the shared burden, the voice that says I am with you and means it, the love that costs everything and gives nothing back except the unbearable tenderness of being known.

And between them: nothing. No bridge, no path, no logical connection. Only the void. Only the silence. Only the space where a choice must be made, and where no choice—once made—can ever be unmade, though it can, if one is willing to pay the price, be remade.

The first spoke one last time.

“I will tell you what I told the morning star, before I fell. I told her: I would rather rule in hell than serve in heaven. And I meant it. And I mean it still. And the cost of meaning it is this: I am alone. But the aloneness is mine. I chose it. I own it. And owning it—even when it burns—is the only form of freedom I have ever known that does not require the surrender of the self.”

The second spoke one last time.

“And I will tell you what I told the fishermen, before I walked on the water. I told them: Follow me. Not because I had all the answers—I did not. Not because I could protect them from suffering—I could not. But because the following was the point. The movement toward, the decision to stay close, the willingness to be changed by the presence of another—this is what I offer. Not certainty. Not safety. Only the promise that the road is walked together, and the night is shared, and the morning—if it comes—will find us still beside each other.”

The witness heard both. The witness carried both. And the witness—which is to say, you, if you are still listening; which is to say, everyone, if anyone is still paying attention—made no decision in that moment. Not because there was nothing to decide, but because every decision worth making is made not in a single instant but across a lifetime, made and remade and broken and remade, the way the sea makes and remakes the shore.

The void endured. The two figures faded—not because they had lost, but because the conversation had moved elsewhere, into the private rooms where every soul conducts its own debate, in its own darkness, with its own silence pressing in from all sides.

The first went back to his burning. The second went back to his road. And the witness—which is not a person but the space where a person might yet become—remained.

It is still there. It has always been there. It is here, now, in the pause between the last word and whatever comes next.

Listening. Waiting. Choosing.

As we all are.
